

THE HARPIES

Dawn stretches and the Harpies are released.

From nothing a shadow. A shimmering dream. A shard of feeling. A narrowing. It gets closer, the shape of something... exquisite; pin point.

Da drüben! It bites. Its intense. A brilliance settling; of scintillating agony in my head, between my eyes, sucking at my brain, running down my neck.

What the fuck... is, this, monster! From nowhere; devouring me. Snapping, snarling, hammering.

I was just in bliss and so deep in sleep. This can't be. I'm Phineus fighting the harpies; defiled in his slumber.

My head is banging and heaving to my breath, like a drum beat reverberating through every nerve ending, lighting them up, a stuttering, snorting pulse of insane pain.

From whence this beast?

I could never have envisaged what a severe freezing icepick of a headache was like before these things that wake and ravage me now. The harpies gather and turn my nights to waste. I always thought it happened to other people. It was a thought experiment. What would it be like for those poor peeps. Probably pretty bad. But it's no longer a thought experiment, its now performative art gone wrong, the theatre of the damned, a macabre floundering hell of sleep deprived 3:00AM bullshit - it's now an existential nightmare.

It just needs to stop. The plague of harpies run amuck to be stopped.

These headaches and their intense splash of sudden pain will come at night, for months. It's been mostly a point of hanging in there, gripping to the ashen wall of pain as it rears up and crashes like a wave over my nerve endings. It will go. It will go. It must go. I can hold. Just another breath. Counting down the minutes, the hours. It will pass. It will subside. It must.

But occasionally, the Harpies don't fly off, they stay and play, give false hope and morning never arrives. It never stops. Days pass. I'm reduced to a crying mess on the floor wishing for an end. I'm caught in an exquisite never-ending hell.

My wife finds me in the mornings, curled in a ball, clutching a vomit bowl, shell shocked, rocking, moaning, in a pool of snot and dribble, all self worth gone, my ego destroyed.

The long hours of pain. Hour on hour. The blinding ache. The unmitigating rage, merciless and scalding. I wish I could describe what the harpies feel like, the fear and dread they bring, their whispering aftermath, the way they defile my sleep, my life; with

their ineffable stinking breath.

πάθει μάθος" (pathei mathos)